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Today I am going to present the beginnings of a more comprehensive project on the role of madness in the decolonial process. In what follows, I will focus particularly on 1) how Frantz Fanon alludes to a return to a childlike state of mind as a way of unlearning colonial logic, and 2) how the existential condition of the child described by Simone de Beauvoir helps us to problematize and interpret Fanon's approach.

The process of colonization is complex and is never fully realized. It requires the constant imposition of a foreign culture on the colonized, and that this culture has a hierarchical structure where the colonized are always symbolically below the colonizer. This is what the psychiatrist from Martinique, Frantz Fanon, diagnoses as a logic of the colonial condition in the early 1950s in his book entitled *Black Skin, White Masks*. Fanon describes how colonial regimes shape public institutions and the social environment in accordance with the learning of colonial logic. So it is not only the colonizers who impose their culture, but also the colonized subjects themselves who, by internalizing colonial logic, despise each other. For Fanon, the West Indian “gradually assimilates the prejudices, myths, and folklore that come from Europe” to eventually become “a slave to this cultural imposition” and “realize that he has been living a lie” (pg. 168-169, Fanon).

The gradual process of assimilation results in the unconscious internalization of colonial logic. The colonized subject learns to identify with the imposed culture and thus imagines himself on the same level as the colonizer. What Fanon calls “living a mistake” occurs when the colonized person who identifies with the imposed culture is socially recognized as inferior to the colonizer. Since the colonized person has unconsciously internalized colonial logic, being socially recognized as inferior to the colonizer causes an identity crisis. Although consciously imagining themselves to be on the same level as the colonizer, they unconsciously know that this is not possible according to the imposed culture. Fanon devotes much of his book to the various psychopathologies or forms of madness that arise from this crisis.

One remedy Fanon proposes for dealing with the uncertain and contradictory condition of the colonial subject is that when a situation reveals the identity “error” we have described, one must “reduce the actual situation to nought and attempt to apprehend reality with the mind of a child” (pg. 170, Fanon). On another occasion, when Fanon discusses the symbolic hegemony of European culture in the unconscious of the West Indian, he argues that “we need to become a child again to understand certain psychic realities” beyond those offered by the imposed culture (pg. 166, Fanon). It is curious that in order to deal with the madness caused by the colonized person's identity “error,” Fanon suggests returning to a childlike state of mind, something that could be interpreted as a form of madness. In the book *The Ethics of Ambiguity*, Simone de Beauvoir explains that “the situation of the child is characterized by finding himself thrown into a universe that he has not helped to establish, that has been modeled without him, and that seems to him an absolute to which he can only submit” (pg. 35, Simone de Beauvoir). De Beauvoir says that although the child has the privilege of “being allowed to play and spend its existence freely,”

it enjoys this existential freedom thanks to its belief in the immutability of “the real world [...] of adults where he is allowed only to respect and obey” (pg. 35, Simone de Beauvoir).

For de Beauvoir, the infantile condition is subjugated to the adult world in a similar way to how the colonized condition is subjugated to the culture imposed by the colonizer. But for Fanon, returning to an infantile state of mind is a way of abandoning the reality imposed by the colonizer's culture. I understand that, for Fanon, regressing to an infantile state of mind represents a process of unlearning colonial logic. Fanon's goal is to bring the colonial subject from a state of unconscious subjugation to a state of liberation from acting under colonial logic. I believe that referring to this process as a “return to the mental state of the child” runs the risk of being interpreted as a transformation that simply exchanges subjugation to the culture imposed by subjugation to the adult world. In the case of the colonial world, these two oppressive realities tend to be equivalent, which would point to a contradiction in Fanon's proposal. In Fanon's text, he also points out the need to recognize the social nature of cultural imposition (pg. 190, Fanon). This implies that the colonial subject must become aware of how the behavior of others affects them and also how their own attitude towards others can reinforce colonial logic. This recognition demanded by Fanon forces the colonial subject to develop a social consciousness that requires taking responsibility for one's actions and their effect on others. According to de Beauvoir, this taking of responsibility for the effect one's existence is something that does not occur in children. The responsibility for children's actions on their environment falls on adults, which is why children can play freely without having to act within the limits of an internalized identity, such as the culture imposed on the colonized. In Fanon's proposal, then, it is necessary to take responsibility for the social effect that one has as a colonized person, as well as to unlearn the internalized colonial logic in order to be able to think with the freedom of a child.

I propose as an open hypothesis that this combination of decolonial remedies offered by Fanon resembles what de Beauvoir calls an open future. De Beauvoir asserts that no logic can determine human existence in a future oriented way and that is why we must practice collective recognition of an indeterminate future, that is, an open future. My argument, which I will not defend today, is that the development of social consciousness together with childlike freedom of thought enables the practice of recognizing an open future and a free existence. By way of conclusion, and in order to tie what I have presented to the theme of my long-term project, I would like to say that if we think of madness as an abandonment of the referential ties between the symbolic structure offered by a culture and common reality, then we can see how returning to the mental state of a child is a kind of madness. That said, we have already seen how careful we must be when interpreting a process of unlearning through what I have called madness. In addition to going mad in a certain way, we have identified how the decolonial process requires a strong social consciousness so that the colonial subject can truly exist freely.